By the late 1930s, there was an almost political consensus that independent India will be a planned economy. As India commenced economic planning by the early 1950s, the Planning Commission of India also went on to define planning. According to the Planning Commission, "Planning involves the acceptance of a clearly defined system of objectives in terms of which to frame overall policies. It also involves the formation of a strategy for promoting the realisation of ends defined. Planning is essentially an attempt at working out a rational solution of problems, an attempt to coordinate means and ends; it is thus different from the traditional hit-and-miss methods by which reforms and reconstruction are often undertaken"[2] .

In the post-War period, a large number of the newly independent countries were attracted towards planning. Many new forces of change kept refining the very idea of planning due to the compulsive necessities of industrialisation or the issue of sustainability of the development process. But to carry forward our discussion, we need a working as well as a contemporary definition of planning. We may define it as *a process of realising well-defined goals by optimum utilisation of the available resources.*[3] While doing economic planning the government sets developmental objectives and attempts to deliberately coordinate the economic decision making over a longer period to influence, direct and in some cases even to control the level and growth of a nation's main economic variables (i.e. income, consumption, employment, saving, investment, exports, imports, etc.).[4]

An economic plan is simply a set of specific economic targets to be achieved in a given period of time with a stated strategy. Economic plans may be either comprehensive or partial. A ***comprehensive plan*** sets targets to cover all major aspects of the economy while a ***partial plan*** may go for setting such targets for a part of the economy (i.e. agriculture, industry, public sector, etc.). Taken broadly, the planning process itself can be described as an exercise in which a government first chooses social objectives, then sets various targets (i.e. economic targets), and finally organises a framework for implementing, coordinating, and monitoring a development plan.[5]

One very important thing which should be clear to all is that the idea of planning first emerged in its applied form and after studying and surveying